PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Fort Wagner & the 54th Massachusetts — A House Divided

The Battle That Was Lost and Won

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Fort Wagner & the 54th Massachusetts — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. When several sources agree, a historian's confidence grows. Read these accounts together and explain what they prove

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1890 — Storming Fort Wagner



Printed nearly 30 years later, this image shows how the nation chose to remember the 54th — as heroes at the very front of the fight

"Storming Fort Wagner" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, 1890, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE A · A NORTHERN NEWSPAPER · 1863 — The report of the charge

"The Fifty-fourth did well and nobly. … They moved up as gallantly as any troops could, and with their enthusiasm they deserved a better fate. … Through the cannon smoke of that dark night … they made Fort

Wagner such a name to the colored race as Bunker Hill has been for ninety years to the white Yankees."
— New York Tribune, 1863. Public domain

— New York Tribune, 1863. Public domain.

SOURCE B · FREDERICK DOUGLASS · 1863 — The argument for citizenship

"Once let the black man get upon his person the brass letters, U.S. … and a musket on his shoulder … and there is no power on earth … which can deny that he has earned the right to citizenship."
— Frederick Douglass, 1863. Public domain

— Frederick Douglass, 1863. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · WHAT HAPPENED

In your own words, what did the 54th Massachusetts do at Fort Wagner on July 18, 1863 — and what was the outcome of the battle itself?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · CORROBORATION

The 1863 newspaper (A), Douglass (B), and the 1890 image all point to the same conclusion. What is it?

- ☐ A. that the 54th captured Fort Wagner easily
- ☐ B. that the courage of Black soldiers proved their valor and their claim to equal citizenship
- ☐ C. that Black soldiers should not have fought
- ☐ D. that the battle had no real importance

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · LOST BATTLE, WON ARGUMENT

The Union lost the assault, and nearly half the regiment fell. Explain why the 54th's defeat is still remembered as a kind of victory. What did it win, even in losing?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

Using Douglass's words (Source B), explain the connection between serving as a soldier and claiming citizenship. Why would proving themselves in battle matter so much to the 180,000 Black men who served?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Fort Wagner & the 54th Massachusetts — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The 54th… The battle itself ended with…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. that the courage of Black soldiers proved their valor and their claim to equal citizenship**

Exactly. From the battle report to Douglass to the later print, all the sources corroborate one message: the 54th's courage proved Black soldiers had earned their place — and their claim to citizenship.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Though they lost the fort, the 54th won… because…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Douglass argued that a Black soldier… This mattered because…"